CUSTODIAN OF CAPITAL

GROWING UP IN HYDERABAD, RITU GANGRADE ARORA was fortunate to have parents who considered education to be the biggest asset one could own. "My mother instilled dreams and ambitions in me, my dad nurtured them and my husband and the entire family helped give wings to them," she says. After college, she had a desire to enter the art world, and she got through the Sir J.J. School of Art in Mumbai. But she ended up doing commerce, which her college principal wasn't happy about since he felt she would have done better in engineering. "In hindsight, it was good that I could follow my interest, and my parents allowed me to do that," she says. Ritu has spent over 27 years in several leadership positions with multinationals, including Allianz and HSBC. At Allianz, she oversees investments in 12 countries, including India, China, Taiwan, Thailand, Indonesia and Malaysia, with nearly $48 billion of assets under management.

For Ritu, a motivating factor in her career has been these organisations' gender-neutral environment. "Allianz is deeply committed to gender diversity, right up to the board level," says the mother of two, whose husband Ashish Arora is CEO of Nxtra Data by Airtel. But over time, people start to forget gender issues and focus on the task at hand, and as long as one delivers, the gender issue stops mattering, she explains.

Apart from leading Allianz Investment Management in the Asia Pacific region and representing Allianz in India as an advisor to the Allianz SE Board, Ritu leads the sustainability and net zero, and gender diversity domains at Allianz in India. "To represent a global financial institution in India speaks volumes about the confidence that Allianz leadership is willing to invest in diverse talent," she says. Allianz is a founding member of the Net Zero Asset Owners Alliance. This, Ritu says, is a very impactful work beyond capital markets.

Schedules can be taxing between the time zones of Singapore, China and Munich, so Ritu has to pursue ruthless time management schedules. However, she finds the interaction with so many cultures enjoyable. ■

–M.G. Arun

Ritu Gangrade Arora, *50*

CEO & CIO-Asia Pacific, Allianz Investment Management, Singapore; India Advisor to Allianz SE Board

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HARDIK CHHABRA

A LARGER CANVAS Squeezes in time between her work schedules to paint